Siblicide and the Blue-footed Booby

Blue-footed Boobies are seabirds native to the Pacific Ocean. They get their food from the ocean, but come to rocky shores and cliffs to breed. The female lays two eggs, roughly five days apart, so that by the time the second chick hatches, the first one has already grown considerably. When food is plentiful, the parents can find enough to feed both offspring until they fly the nest (fledge). However, when food is scarce, the larger chick will peck its junior sibling to death. The older chick can then get more food, and is more likely to fledge. If it does not murder its sibling when food is scarce, both chicks may starve.

This behavior, based exclusively on the availability of food, is called “facultative siblicide.” In contrast, masked boobies practice “obligate siblicide”—the first-hatched chick nearly always kills its sibling, regardless of how much food is available.